



THE CUSTOMER LEADERSHIP SERIES

Customer Service Playbook

Building service operations that are fast, consistent, accountable and human.

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Customer Service Is an Operating System

Great service is created when people, process, technology and leadership work together around the customer.

Customer Service is not simply answering contacts. It is the operating discipline that protects trust when customers need help, clarity or resolution.

CLEAR

Customers understand what is happening.

FAST

Urgency matches customer impact.

OWNED

One person remains accountable.

CONSISTENT

Standards do not depend on who answers.

HUMAN

Customers feel heard and respected.

Service Principle

The customer should never have to understand our internal organization in order to get help.

From Contact to Confidence

Every interaction should move through a controlled service flow with clear ownership and measurable outcomes.



What Good Looks Like

Accurate diagnosis • minimal transfers • realistic expectations • proactive updates • complete resolution • useful documentation

What Creates Friction

Repeated explanations • unclear ownership • silent delays • scripted responses • unnecessary escalation • unresolved root causes

SLA & Priority Framework

Response and resolution targets should reflect customer impact - not treat every contact as equally urgent.

Priority	Customer Impact	Operating Response	Communication
P1 • Critical	Business stopped / severe impact	Immediate ownership	Executive visibility
P2 • High	Major functionality affected	Priority queue	Frequent updates
P3 • Standard	Normal service issue	Standard SLA	Clear resolution path
P4 • Low	Question / guidance	Knowledge-led	Efficient response

Targets should be calibrated to the business model, customer promise, staffing model and actual service capacity.

Customer Service KPI Dashboard

Operational metrics matter most when they explain the quality, efficiency and customer outcome behind the contact.

94%

CSAT

Customer perception after service

< 2h

FRT

Speed to first meaningful response

78%

FCR

Issues resolved without repeat contact

96%

SLA

Commitments met within target

92%

QA

Quality and process performance

6%

REOPEN

Resolution durability

Measurement Rule

Never optimize one metric in isolation. Faster handling with poor resolution quality simply moves cost and frustration into the next contact.

Quality Assurance Framework

QA should evaluate the customer outcome and identify system improvements - not merely score agent compliance.

Accuracy

Was the information correct?

Ownership

Did the advisor take responsibility?

Communication

Was the response clear and structured?

Empathy

Was the customer's situation understood?

Resolution

Was the issue actually solved?

Compliance

Were required policies followed?

Effort

Was unnecessary work avoided?

Documentation

Can the next person understand the case?

Escalation Management

Escalation is a controlled response to risk - not simply transferring a difficult customer to someone senior.

1

Acknowledge

Recognize impact and urgency.

2

Assess

Determine severity, risk and dependencies.

3

Mobilize

Bring in the right internal owners.

4

Communicate

Set cadence and expectations.

5

Resolve

Deliver corrective action.

6

Prevent

Find root cause and stop recurrence.

Escalation Principle

Silence destroys confidence. Even without the final answer, customers should know who owns the issue, what is happening and when the next update will arrive.

Coaching & Performance Cycle

High-performing service teams are built through expectations, observation, feedback, practice and accountability.



Coaching should improve judgment, confidence and consistency - not just correct isolated mistakes.

Workforce & Capacity Management

Customer experience deteriorates when demand, staffing and skills are not aligned.

1

Forecast Demand

Volume • channel • seasonality • events

2

Plan Capacity

Coverage • shrinkage • occupancy • leave

3

Match Skills

Routing • complexity • product knowledge

4

Monitor Intraday

Queues • SLA risk • backlog • exceptions

5

Adjust

Reallocate • prioritize • communicate

6

Review

Learn from forecast and staffing variance

Workforce management is not only a cost function. It is a customer promise function because staffing decisions determine accessibility, speed and service consistency.

Knowledge Management

The right answer should be easy to find, easy to understand and easy to keep current.

Single Source of Truth

One trusted knowledge environment.

Clear Ownership

Every article has an accountable owner.

Simple Language

Write for customer and frontline usability.

Searchability

Use consistent naming, tags and structure.

Change Control

Update content when products or policies change.

Feedback Loop

Let frontline teams flag gaps and errors.

Turn Contacts Into Intelligence

Service conversations reveal where products, processes, policies and communication are failing customers.

Contact Driver

Why did the customer contact us?

Repeat Contact

Why was the first interaction insufficient?

Escalation

Where did normal service fail?

Complaint

What expectation was broken?

Root Cause

What created the issue upstream?

Improvement

What should change permanently?

The best Customer Service teams do not only solve individual contacts. They reduce the number of reasons customers need to contact the company in the first place.

90-Day Customer Service Action Plan

A practical sequence for stabilizing service, raising quality and building an improvement engine.

DAYS 1–30

DIAGNOSE

- Review service data
- Map contact drivers
- Assess SLAs and backlog
- Review QA
- Listen to frontline teams
- Identify critical pain points

DAYS 31–60

STANDARDIZE

- Define service standards
- Recalibrate SLAs
- Strengthen QA
- Clarify escalation paths
- Improve knowledge
- Launch coaching cadence

DAYS 61–90

OPTIMIZE

- Automate repeatable work
- Reduce top contact drivers
- Improve workforce planning
- Measure customer effort
- Close process gaps
- Set next-quarter priorities

Six Dimensions of Service Excellence

CUSTOMER

Understand the need and impact.

PEOPLE

Build capability and accountability.

PROCESS

Make service easy and repeatable.

QUALITY

Protect accuracy and consistency.

PERFORMANCE

Measure outcomes and capacity.

IMPROVEMENT

Remove root causes and friction.

Final Principle

Great Customer Service is not defined by how quickly a ticket disappears. It is defined by whether the customer received the right outcome, with the least unnecessary effort, from a team that took ownership.

Technology enables service. People and operating discipline earn trust.